🥔 Washington Crops: Potatoes, Wheat & Apples: Reading

Ag Science 1 · Unit 2 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Bedlington Farm PowerPoint, WA Wheat Barley and Potatoes, Potato Lab, Cosmic Crisp Apples, Apple Taste Lab

Name: _____

Three Washington Crops

Dick Bedlington Farms started in 1942 with 4 acres and now grows about 1,200 acres of potatoes in Deming, Everson, Lynden and Ferndale. They grow certified seed potatoes, potatoes planted to grow new plants. Whatcom is good for seed because it is isolated between the ocean and mountains, so there are fewer insects and diseases, and the soil drains well. They rotate potatoes with wheat, grass, corn and green beans.

A potato is a tuber, the swollen underground stem of the plant. The eyes are buds where new sprouts grow. Above ground the plant has leaves, stems, flowers and small fruit. Farmers harvest when the vines die back.

In the Columbia Basin, long sunny days and rich soil give high potato yields. There is very little rain, so farms irrigate with water from the Columbia River. Eastern Washington's dry hills grow wheat, mostly soft white wheat used for noodles, crackers and cakes. Most Washington wheat is exported, much of it to Asia. Barley is used for animal feed and malt.

Washington grows more than half of the apples in the United States. Bees pollinate the blossoms, and growers thin extra apples so the rest grow big. Grafting, joining a branch of one tree onto the roots of another, keeps each variety the same.

Cosmic Crisp was bred at Washington State University by crossing Enterprise and Honeycrisp. Dr. Bruce Barritt developed it, and growers' fees paid for the research. It stays crisp in storage for about a year. In the apple taste lab, students compare varieties like Gala, Granny Smith, Fuji and Cosmic Crisp.

Check your reading

1. Why is Whatcom County a good place to grow seed potatoes?

2. What kind of wheat does Washington mostly grow, and where does most of it go?

3. What two apples were crossed to make Cosmic Crisp?